

January

SPECIAL EVENTS

PHASES OF THE MOON

	Full Moon	New Moon
2008	January 22	January 8
2009	January 11	January 26
2010	January 30	January 15
2011	January 19	January 4
2012	January 9	January 23

ECLIPSES

2009: January 26 An annular eclipse of the Sun is visible from the Indian Ocean and Indonesia; a partial eclipse is seen from southern Africa, southern and eastern Asia, and western and southern Australia.

2010: January 15 An annular eclipse of the Sun is visible from eastern Africa, the Indian Ocean, southern India, and southeastern Asia. A partial solar eclipse is seen from southern and eastern Africa, the Middle East, and central, southern, and southeastern Asia.

2011: January 4 A partial eclipse of the Sun is visible from northern Africa, Europe, the Middle East, and central Asia.

THE PLANETS

2008: January 22
Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude -0.4 .

2009: January 4
Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude -0.4 .

2009: January 14
Venus is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude -4.5 .

2010: January 27
Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude -0.1 .

2010: January 29
Mars is at opposition, magnitude -1.2 . At midnight, it is visible to the south from northern latitudes and to the north from southern latitudes.

2011: January 8
Venus is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude -4.4 .

2011: January 9
Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude -0.2 .

Opposition and elongation are explained on [page 14](#)

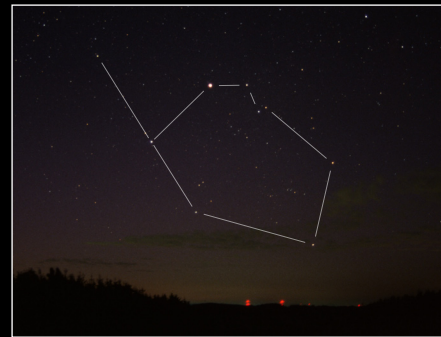
The impressive constellation of Orion dominates the scene this month. The hunter's recognizable figure, with raised club and lion pelt, is easy to spot; and in his sword is the celebrated Orion Nebula. His two hunting dogs, Canis Major and Canis Minor, are close by. Canis Major includes Sirius, the brightest star of all in Earth's night sky.

NORTHERN LATITUDES

Orion stands proud above the southern horizon with his dogs to the left of his feet. The dogs are located by their bright stars, brilliant Sirius in Canis Major, and Procyon, the eighth-brightest star of all, in Canis Minor. At either side of Orion's head are the constellations Gemini and Taurus. Gemini is identified by the two bright stars Castor and Pollux.

The head of Taurus, the bull, is close to the lion pelt in Orion's hand. The Hyades star cluster, easily visible to the naked eye, locates the bull's face, and the bright star Aldebaran marks its eye. Aldebaran is a red giant, and its coloring is apparent to the naked eye.

Directly overhead and within the path of the Milky Way is the constellation of Auriga, found by its bright star, Capella. The Milky Way flows into Cassiopeia, whose stars make a recognizable "W" or "M" shape in the sky, depending on whether they are above or below the north celestial pole.



Capella and Auriga

Bright Capella (top center) identifies the location of the constellation Auriga, the charioteer. It actually consists of two giant stars and has a yellow tint. It contains two star clusters, M38 and M36, just visible to the naked eye. Binoculars reveal them as fuzzy patches and confirm their presence.

